

DUKE SERIES TRILOGY OUTLINE

THE DUKE SAVAGE TRILOGY SERIES OUTLINE & SYNOPSES Simon J. Cleary

SERIES NORTH STAR

Truth does not destroy power. It forces power to evolve.

Each book in the trilogy advances this thesis one stage further:

BOOK 1 — GHOSTS IN THE ASH: Truth wounds the mechanism.

BOOK 2 — RESIDUE: Truth maps the architecture above the mechanism.

BOOK 3 — THE RECORD: Truth forces a choice between exposure and redesign.

The trilogy's emotional spine is Duke and Julie — not as father and daughter reconciling, but as two people who love each other and cannot follow each other into where they each have to go. The case is always the vehicle. The relationship is always the cost.

BOOK 1: GHOSTS IN THE ASH

SYNOPSIS

Duke Savage — disgraced gonzo journalist turned digital investigator, mostly-recovered fentanyl addict, estranged father — is hired by Victoria Cross to find a missing woman named Sarah Chu. The case rapidly expands: Sarah isn't missing by accident. She's been systematically erased by the Babylon Circuit, a distributed power network that operates through the language of bureaucracy rather than violence. Its current Los Angeles operation — run through a nonprofit called Kingdom Cares and a data platform called CivicBridge — is clearing the right-of-way for a \$40 billion federal freight corridor by displacing 847 families through cascading administrative failures. Duke's investigation takes him from Los Angeles to Baltimore to Arlington, building the evidentiary architecture that will bring the mechanism to federal court. He

wins — partially. The mechanism is wounded. The corridor will still be built. The man who designed the framework, Daniel Voss, gives Duke a name on a plain white card: Thomas R. Carver. The man above all of it. The man the case never reached.

Duke's daughter Julie — estranged, brilliant, code-native digital forensics investigator — has been running her own parallel investigation for eleven weeks without telling him. Their confrontation in her Santa Monica apartment is the emotional core of the novel: Julie showing Duke what his methodology costs from the outside. The case closes. The federal record exists. The audit is never closed. Julie's text arrives on Duke's phone: she has the evening free.

The door is open. But something has shifted that doesn't un-shift. The epilogue seeds the next case: CONTINUUM — the same architecture, different sector, and a name Duke doesn't yet understand. Thomas R. Carver.

BOOK 2: *RESIDUE*

THEME: Power doesn't hide. It franchises.

TONE: The heat of Book 1 turns colder. More institutional. More dangerous. Duke is no longer operating in a case he controls. He's operating inside an architecture that was designed around people like him.

CHARACTER STATUS ENTERING BOOK 2

Duke Savage: The Pacific Meridian case is in federal proceedings. Duke is taking routine work. The CONTINUUM file is open on his desk. He and Julie have had dinner twice. The professional détente is fragile. He is on the pill sequence. The tremor is manageable. The case is coming.

Julie Savage: She knows what Residue is. She hasn't named it to Duke yet. She's been running it for four months — small interventions, systems-level repairs, protecting people from administrative cascades before they start. She's been watching the CONTINUUM architecture from her side. She sees what Duke sees. She's drawing different conclusions about what to do.

Sarah Chu: In federal witness protection. Testifying. Processing. She appears in Book 2 as a source rather than a client — someone who understands the architecture better than almost anyone alive and is now deciding what to do with that understanding from the inside of a system that is supposed to be protecting her.

Victoria Cross: In cooperation with federal prosecutors. Her testimony is the architecture of Book 1's legal case. She is not done. She is methodically ensuring that every door she helped build is documented before she steps away from the only world she's known.

Raoul: Still running his community network. The CONTINUUM connection hits his population — adults in supportive housing programs whose records are being scrambled by the same architecture that displaced Felix. This is the case that becomes personal for him in a way Book 1's case wasn't.

Joanna Park: Now aware that the Pacific Meridian case was one node. She is building toward something larger. She needs Duke's investigative methodology and finds it both indispensable and infuriating.

NEW CHARACTERS — BOOK 2

Detective Maria Guadalupe "Lupita" Ortiz: LAPD, 15-year veteran, honest cop who has survived a corrupt department through disciplined restraint. She's been tracking a pattern in her precinct — adults with mental health histories disappearing from supportive housing programs, their records scrambled by a new data platform. She reaches out to Duke not through official channels but through Raoul's community network. She is steady heat under pressure. Duke trusts her because she doesn't ask him to trust her.

Tommy: 24 years old. His younger sister was recruited into a Circuit cultural operation three years ago — not trafficked, absorbed. She's alive and unreachable. He's been running data exploits against Circuit infrastructure for eighteen months. Grief made into a technical instrument. He finds Duke through Julie, which tells Duke something he isn't ready to think about yet. Tommy is brilliant, impulsive, and emotionally raw. He will make a decision in Book 2 that costs someone. It won't be the wrong decision. That's what makes it hard.

Jerome: The specific human cost that cracks Julie's professional deference to Duke's methodology. Jerome is forty-one. He has been stable in a supportive housing program for three years — medication-compliant, working part-time, rebuilding. His records are scrambled by CONTINUUM in February. By March he is living with his sister. By April his stability has deteriorated. Duke is investigating CONTINUUM when Jerome happens. Duke files it. Julie doesn't file it. That's the difference.

SCENE-BY-SCENE OUTLINE — BOOK 2

ACT I: THE CONTINUUM (Chapters 1–8) Establishing the new case, the new threat, the new team configuration.

Chapter 1: SEPTEMBER Duke at the desk. The CONTINUUM file is open. The Pacific Meridian federal proceeding is running without him. Routine work. The woman whose brother is in the system sits across from him. He takes the case. The McLean geography surfaces. He opens a new file. Closing line: The audit was never closed. It just found a new address.

Chapter 2: ROOT ACCESS Duke runs the CONTINUUM architecture. Same language as DataBridge. Same geographic footprint. Different sector — healthcare and supportive housing rather than residential displacement. He finds Tommy's digital fingerprints already in the system:

someone has been running interference against CONTINUUM's data feeds for months. Sloppy. Effective. Young. Duke has a new thread and hasn't decided whether to pull it.

Chapter 3: LUPITA Ortiz reaches Duke through Raoul. She's been tracking four disappearances from supportive housing programs in her precinct — not deaths, vanishings. Adults with mental health histories whose records have been scrambled so thoroughly they can no longer access their own medication or housing subsidy. She has a pattern. She needs someone who speaks the language of the pattern. Duke recognises the CONTINUUM architecture in her files immediately. Her voice: she stops talking when she has nothing useful to add. Duke respects this more than he can easily articulate.

Chapter 4: TOMMY Duke finds Tommy. Or Tommy finds Duke — the distinction matters and they will argue about it. Tommy is running a one-man digital resistance operation against CONTINUUM's data infrastructure, motivated entirely by his sister. He's been watching Duke's Pacific Meridian case in the federal record. He came because Julie told him to. Duke notes this without pursuing it. Tommy's methodology is the opposite of Duke's: fast, aggressive, offensive. Duke needs both. He doesn't fully trust either.

Chapter 5: JEROME Duke interviews Jerome's sister. Jerome's stability has been deteriorating for six weeks. The timeline of the CONTINUUM record scramble maps exactly onto the timeline of his decline. Duke files this as evidence. Julie, who Duke doesn't know has been tracking CONTINUUM for four months, is already at Jerome's sister's apartment when Duke arrives. She got there first. She's been helping Jerome navigate the correction process for three weeks. Duke didn't know she was here. She didn't tell him. First visible crack in the deference.

Chapter 6: THE CARVER RECORD Duke runs Thomas R. Carver. The name on Voss's card. What he finds: a profile so managed it's almost invisible. A career in federal policy advisory work spanning twenty years. Board positions at four foundations. A fellowship at Brookings. A consulting practice in McLean that shares a registered agent with CONTINUUM Health Solutions. Not a criminal. Not a visible power player. The specific kind of person who has operated in the space between institutional legitimacy and private interest for long enough that the space has become invisible. Carver isn't running CONTINUUM. Carver designed the model CONTINUUM runs on. Same thing he did with the housing protocol. Different sector. Same architecture.

Chapter 7: WHAT JULIE BUILT Duke finds out about Residue. Not from Julie — from Tommy, who references it casually, assuming Duke knows. Duke doesn't know. Tommy realises this a sentence too late. The conversation that follows is short, operational, and costs something between Duke and Tommy that won't fully repair. Duke doesn't call Julie that night. He sits with it. He closes the log the way he closed the log on the 4:47 query. Except this time the log is larger and he knows exactly what he's not pulling on.

Chapter 8: THE TEAM Duke, Raoul, Ortiz, Tommy. Four people with four completely different operating methodologies who have arrived at the same architecture from different directions. Duke convenes them — not as a team leader, as the person who has the most complete picture

and needs the others to fill the gaps his methodology can't reach. Julie is not in this room. Duke invited her. She declined. She's running Residue. She has her own picture. The first time in the trilogy that Duke operates without her consent.

ACT II: THE PROTOCOL (Chapters 9–18) The investigation deepens. The human cost accumulates. Julie and Duke operate in parallel — not against each other, but with increasing divergence in method and conclusion.

Chapter 9: CARVER'S NETWORK CONTINUUM Health Solutions is one of eleven county-contracted data platforms in seven states running the same architecture. Not a pilot this time — a fully deployed commercial model, post-correction for the legal vulnerabilities the Pacific Meridian case exposed. Carver watched the Voss prosecution and learned from it. The new version has better insulation. Cleaner corporate structures. More plausible deniability at every authorization level. Duke looks at it and understands: he taught them how to hide better.

Chapter 10: LUPITA'S COST Ortiz is identified. Not by Duke's investigation — by something in her department. A fellow officer. The Circuit's security node in LAPD. She's put on administrative leave pending a conduct review. The allegation: misuse of confidential database access. The evidence: a query log showing her running CONTINUUM-adjacent searches outside her case jurisdiction. The log is accurate. The characterisation of it as misconduct is not. Duke watches Ortiz become a case study in what the mechanism does to honest people inside institutions. She takes it without drama. She doesn't stop working.

Chapter 11: JEROME Jerome is hospitalised. Psychiatric crisis, precipitated by the breakdown of his stability protocol. Duke is in an interview in Silver Lake when it happens. He finds out from Raoul. He files it the way he files everything. Julie, when she finds out, does not file it. She makes a decision Duke doesn't know about yet. This is the Jerome moment. The crack deepens.

Chapter 12: THE CARVER INTERVIEW Duke gets to Carver. Not through confrontation — through the federal advisory working group that Carver sits on, which Voss identified in Book 1's Rosslyn meeting. Duke attends a public session. He sits in the back. He watches Carver operate. Carver is not a monster. He is a man who has decided that certain categories of harm are acceptable costs for certain categories of benefit, and who has organized his life so that the harm and the benefit occupy different institutional containers and he only attends the container with the benefit. Duke recognises the cage. It's more sophisticated than Lyle's cage. Carver built it himself.

Chapter 13: WHAT RESIDUE DOES Duke and Julie have the first professional confrontation of Book 2. Not about the case — about Jerome. Julie has spent three weeks navigating Jerome through the correction process. His records are partially restored. His medication access is reinstated. He is not hospitalised again. Duke's investigation of the architecture that caused Jerome's crisis is months from producing legal remedy. Julie's intervention produced result in three weeks. "I can't keep watching you investigate things I could fix." Duke's answer: "Fixing it

without exposing it means it runs again next week. On the next Jerome. And the one after that." They're both right. The room holds it.

Chapter 14: TOMMY'S DECISION Tommy runs an offensive operation against CONTINUUM's data infrastructure. Not Duke's sanction — his own judgment. He identifies a vulnerability in the platform's authentication layer and uses it to restore records for forty-seven individuals whose data has been scrambled. Not a leak. Not a legal filing. A direct intervention in the system's data architecture. It works. Forty-seven people have their records back. Duke finds out after the fact. The operation left traces. Carver's security team finds the traces. Tommy is now in the threat model. This was not Duke's call. This is the first serious cost of operating without full information sharing between the Duke methodology and the Residue methodology.

Chapter 15: ORTIZ MAKES A MOVE Still on administrative leave, Ortiz makes a quiet play. She has been building her own case file for three months — not official, entirely personal. She takes it to an Internal Affairs contact she's known for a decade and trusts completely. The contact reviews it. The contact is clean. The contact is also, Duke will later discover, adjacent to something that is not clean. Ortiz doesn't know this. Duke finds out too late for it to not matter. The honest cop in a dishonest machine makes a move that costs her because the machine is more dishonest than she'd accounted for. She survives it. The cost is real.

Chapter 16: THE HEALTHCARE ANGLE Park brings Duke into a conference call with a federal public health attorney she's been consulting. CONTINUUM's architecture in the healthcare sector constitutes a different category of federal violation than the housing protocol — Americans with Disabilities Act implications, healthcare privacy law, the specific federal protections around mental health records. The legal architecture of Book 2's case is more complex than Book 1's. The remedies are less clear. The defendants are more sophisticated. Park needs more. Duke needs more. What he needs is in Carver's advisory working group documentation. What he needs requires someone inside the federal policy infrastructure. He looks at Victoria Cross's current status.

Chapter 17: VICTORIA'S LAST MOVE Victoria, now fully cooperated and in the specific post-cooperation limbo of someone who has burned their world down and is deciding what to build in the space, agrees to one more thing. She has a contact on the federal advisory working group that Carver chairs. A contact who is not compromised — who is, like Fenn in Book 1, someone inside the mechanism who has been looking for the right exit. She won't tell Duke who it is. She'll tell the contact about Duke. The contact will decide. Victoria is not managing anyone anymore. She is making introductions and stepping back. This is the last time Victoria Cross appears in the trilogy. Her final line is not dramatic. It is precise. "I've given you the door. Opening it is your work."

Chapter 18: PARALLEL LINES Duke and Julie are running parallel investigations of the same architecture from different methodologies. Duke maps it from the outside — corporate registrations, federal filings, the money. Julie maps it from the inside — the data architecture, the API endpoints, the places where the system can be accessed and corrected. They share information. They do not share conclusions. The information sharing is functional. The

conclusions are incompatible. Duke is building toward exposure. Julie is building toward redesign. At the end of this chapter Duke finds something in the federal advisory working group documentation that doesn't belong. A name he recognises from somewhere he can't immediately place. He files it. He'll know why it matters before the chapter ends. He just doesn't know what it will cost yet.

ACT III: THE FRACTURE (Chapters 19–26) The case converges. The methodology diverges. The loss that defines Book 3 has its origin here.

Chapter 19: CARVER'S RESPONSE Carver moves. Not against Duke — against Residue. He has identified the pattern of Julie's interventions. He doesn't know the name yet. He knows the methodology. Systematic record restoration in CONTINUUM's affected population. Someone with root access to the data architecture who is using it defensively rather than offensively. The Circuit's healthcare node identifies Residue as an anomaly. Not a threat — an anomaly. For now. The classification matters because anomalies get studied. Threats get suppressed. Julie knows she's been found. She adjusts. She doesn't tell Duke.

Chapter 20: THE NAME Duke identifies the name from Chapter 18. It's a junior member of Carver's federal advisory working group. A policy researcher in her early thirties. Clean record. Legitimate career. The specific quality of someone who has been in the system long enough to understand how it works without yet having made the decision about what to do with that understanding. She is not compromised. She is positioned. Duke reaches out. The contact Victoria made. Her name is Alana Chen. She has been waiting for exactly this call for eight months. She has documentation that puts Carver in the authorization chain for CONTINUUM's healthcare deployment. Not a whistleblower. A witness who has been organizing her evidence and waiting for someone who knew how to use it. She is afraid. She is precise. She reminds Duke of Elaine Booth.

Chapter 21: DUKE AND JULIE (THE SECOND CONFRONTATION) The professional confrontation that Book 2 has been building toward. Duke presents the case architecture to Julie — Carver, the federal advisory working group, Alana Chen, the ADA violations, the path to federal criminal exposure. He wants Residue's data on the CONTINUUM architecture as part of the evidentiary package. He is asking her to contribute her work to his methodology. She declines. Not because she won't help — she has already shared the data. Because she will not subordinate Residue's operation to the exposure timeline. The forty-seven people whose records Tommy restored cannot wait for the federal case to run. Jerome cannot wait. The next Jerome cannot wait. "You build the record. I'll fix the people. We can do both." "We can't do both without coordinating. And you won't coordinate." "I won't be managed." The line that ends the scene is hers. It's not angry. It's the specific finality of a decision that was made a long time ago and is only now being stated as fact: "I'm not your case, Duke. I never was."

Chapter 22: THE COST OF TOMMY'S DECISION Carver's security team has been following Tommy's traces since Chapter 14. They have identified his methodology and — through the methodology — his connection to Residue and therefore to Julie. They do not have Julie's name yet. They have a pattern. Tommy is confronted. Not physically — administratively. His records

are scrambled. His freelance contracts disappear from the platforms. His sister's status in the Circuit cultural operation is changed in a way that communicates the change was not accidental. Tommy makes a choice: go to ground and protect himself, or stay operational and accept the cost. He stays operational. He tells Duke what happened. He doesn't tell Duke about the sister's status change. He doesn't want it to affect Duke's calculation. Duke finds out anyway. This is the moment Duke understands that the people working alongside him have their own accounting and he doesn't always get to see the full ledger. Raoul's voice: "Grief is a heavy inventory. If you don't move it, it sits in the warehouse and collects interest." Tommy is moving it. Duke can't stop him.

Chapter 23: PARK MAKES THE CALL The federal case is ready. Alana Chen will testify. The ADA violations connect Carver to the CONTINUUM authorization chain in a way that survives challenge. Park has built the architecture. She needs one more thing: the data on Residue's interventions, which constitutes evidence of the harm being done in real time. Julie's data. Which Julie controls. Julie agrees to provide it — but on one condition. The condition is not about her protection or Residue's exposure. It is about how the federal case frames the remedy. She will not accept a remedy that simply shuts CONTINUUM down. She wants the federal case to require redesign — an open architecture standard for county-contracted data platforms that makes the next CONTINUUM structurally impossible. Park looks at this. It is legally creative. It is unusual. It is doable. She agrees to try. Duke is in the room. He looks at his daughter negotiating the terms of a federal remedy for a case she has been running parallel to his for months. He doesn't say anything. He recognizes the methodology. It is his and it isn't.

Chapter 24: THE CARVER MEETING Duke and Carver. The analog confrontation the trilogy has been building toward since Voss put a card on a diner table in Chapter 24 of Book 1. This is not the California Club. This is a federal advisory working group session, public record, Duke in the audience. Afterward, in a corridor. Carver knows who Duke is. He has known since Pacific Meridian. He watched that case as a learning event. He is not afraid of Duke. He is curious about him. The curiosity is clinical. "You keep building the record," Carver says. "I keep adjusting the architecture. I'm not sure what you think the endpoint is." Duke's answer: "The endpoint is your name in the federal record next to what your architecture cost." Carver: "My name is already in twelve federal advisory working group reports. I'm not hiding, Mr. Savage. I'm embedded. There's a difference." Duke: "The record I'm building isn't advisory. It's criminal." Carver looks at him. Not afraid. Not impressed. The specific quality of a man who has been building the thing that can't be destroyed. Who has watched people try. "How's your daughter?" he says. Duke doesn't answer. He walks out. In the elevator, the tremor is in both hands.

Chapter 25: RESIDUE SURFACES Carver's security node has Julie's name. They move — not against her, against Residue's operational infrastructure. Three of the eleven county-contracted data platforms Residue has been working through shut down access simultaneously. The record restoration pipeline is cut. Thirty-two individuals whose cases were in progress lose their access point. The intervention fails mid-sequence. For two of them, the failure has immediate consequences. One is Jerome. Duke finds out. He goes to Julie. She is already managing the fallout. She is precise, controlled, operational. She is not asking for help. She is, Duke understands, exactly as capable of managing this as he would be. More capable, in the specific

technical dimension. The loss he feels is not for Jerome. It is for the moment he understands she doesn't need him to be the person who fixes it. That she never did.

Chapter 26: THE FEDERAL CASE RUNS Alana Chen testifies. The ADA violations are in the federal record. CONTINUUM Health Solutions' county contracts are suspended pending federal review. Carver's name is in the record. The open architecture remedy Park negotiated with Julie is in the federal order as a required corrective standard. It is the first time a federal consent decree has required a county-contracted data platform to operate under open architecture principles. Julie's condition. Met. The case closes. The record exists. Carver is in it. He is not arrested. Not yet. His legal exposure is real and his attorneys are managing it and he is still on the federal advisory working group because the working group does not yet know what the federal record contains. He will know within a week. He will adjust. He always adjusts. The corridor is not the point. The corridor never was. Ending: Duke at the desk. Two files open. CONTINUUM — closed. A new file. A name from Alana Chen's working group documentation that didn't belong there. A name Carver kept close. The next node. The next architecture. The audit was never closed.

EPILOGUE — BOOK 2 Six months later. Duke and Julie have dinner. It is the third dinner since Book 1 ended. They talk about the open architecture consent decree. They talk about Tommy, whose freelance contracts came back after the federal case ran — the Circuit recalibrating, deciding Tommy was more useful observed than suppressed. They do not talk about Residue by name. Duke doesn't ask. Julie doesn't offer. The lamp is on in her apartment when he leaves. He sees it from the street. He drives east. Somewhere in a federal advisory working group report from 2019, in a footnote nobody has looked at, Thomas R. Carver's signature appears on a recommendation that changed a single line of federal health data governance policy. One line. The line that made CONTINUUM architecturally possible. Duke has found it. He has filed it. In Book 3, he will understand what it cost.

BOOK 3: *THE RECORD*

THEME: The mechanism doesn't fear exposure. It fears irrelevance.

TONE: Colder than Book 2. Quieter. More personal. The gonzo paranoia has been replaced by something more surgical. Duke is older. The case is bigger. The cost is closer to home.

CHARACTER STATUS ENTERING BOOK 3

Duke Savage: He has two successful federal cases in the record. He is not celebrated. He is watched. Carver has had four years to study Duke's methodology and design around it. The new cases that come to Duke are harder — the targets are better insulated, the institutional language is more sophisticated, the authorization chains are more distributed. He is still

effective. He is tiring. The pill sequence is current. The tremor is in both hands some mornings. He does not tell anyone.

Julie Savage: Residue has been operating for three years. It is not a secret exactly — it is unacknowledged. The federal open architecture consent decree from Book 2 has generated a community of practice around it. People in the data forensics world know something called Residue exists. They don't know who runs it. Julie has kept it that way through discipline and operational rigor that would make Duke proud if he let himself say so. She is not beyond his reach because she is hiding. She is beyond his reach because she is fully herself now. They speak monthly. They have dinner quarterly. He loves her. He cannot follow her where she has gone.

Raoul: Three years older. He has lost two people from his network to the CONTINUUM fallout — not deaths, absorptions. People who accepted the system's terms because the system's terms were the only terms available. He is still working. He is not still intact. The grief inventory has been moved. He is still carrying some of it.

Ortiz: Reinstated after eighteen months on administrative leave. The conduct review found insufficient evidence of misconduct — because the evidence against her had been manufactured, and manufactured evidence has seams. She is back. She is different. The machine tried to eat her and failed, and she knows it more precisely now than she did before. She and Duke have a working relationship built on mutual respect and the specific trust of people who have each watched the other get hit and get back up.

Tommy: 27 now. His sister is still in the Circuit's cultural operation. He has accepted — not made peace with, accepted — that she may be there by choice now. That the Circuit's recruitment is sophisticated enough that choice and coercion become indistinguishable after three years. He is still running digital operations. Faster, better, more disciplined. Residue has become his primary operational home, which is something Duke knows and has filed without pulling on.

Thomas R. Carver: In the federal record. Not arrested. Not charged. His attorneys have managed his exposure into a shape that is uncomfortable but survivable. He has not been removed from the federal advisory working group — the working group has quietly restructured his role, which communicates what the federal record cannot yet prove. He has been watching Duke and Julie for three years. He has adjusted his methodology based on what he learned. He is about to make a move that is larger and more consequential than anything in the first two books. Not out of desperation. Out of patience.

THE CASE — BOOK 3

Carver's play is not the housing corridor or the healthcare platform. It is the federal data governance framework itself. The recommendation he signed in 2019 — the footnote Duke found at the end of Book 2 — changed a single line of federal health data policy. That line is about to become the foundation of a new federal data integration standard that will be applied

across eleven government agencies and forty-two states. If it does, the architecture Carver has been building for fifteen years becomes the operating system for the federal government's interaction with the most vulnerable populations in the country. Not a corridor. Not a platform. A standard. The mechanism doesn't hide in companies anymore. It hides in policy.

SCENE-BY-SCENE OUTLINE — BOOK 3

ACT I: THE STANDARD (Chapters 1–8)

Chapter 1: THE FOOTNOTE Duke has been working the 2019 footnote for eight months. He understands what it did. He doesn't yet understand what it's about to do. He calls Park. Park calls her DOJ contact. The DOJ contact is quiet for a long time before responding. "That standard goes to committee in sixty days." The case is open before Duke has a client.

Chapter 2: NO CLIENT Duke investigates without a client for the first time. This is the structural change that defines Book 3: the threat is not to an individual or a community. It is to a policy framework. Duke has no Marisol Reyes. No Sarah Chu. No specific person to protect whose face he can hold onto when the machinery gets too abstract. He has the footnote and the committee timeline and the knowledge that if he doesn't build the case in sixty days the mechanism becomes institutional infrastructure. Raoul gives him the people: a family in Youngstown, one of the original Baltimore pilot families, now in Ohio, whose lives have been a rolling administrative crisis for seven years. They are the face. Their name goes at the top of the file.

Chapter 3: ORTIZ'S INTELLIGENCE Ortiz has been tracking something inside the LAPD's data infrastructure for six months. A new platform — not CONTINUUM, a successor system, deployed through a county mental health contract. The platform has one feature that CONTINUUM didn't have: it interfaces directly with the federal criminal justice database. Not reading from it. Writing to it. The specific administrative horror of a system that can place a flag in a federal criminal record without a criminal proceeding. Duke looks at this and understands: Carver has been iterating. The housing protocol displaced people. The healthcare protocol destabilized them. The justice-adjacent protocol makes them permanently, federally harder to believe.

Chapter 4: JULIE Duke goes to Julie directly. He tells her what he has. The committee timeline. The Youngstown family. The justice platform. He asks for Residue's help — not her data, not her network. Her. He is asking her to work the case alongside him. She is quiet for a long time. "You're asking me to subordinate Residue's timeline to yours again." "I'm asking you to run them in parallel with full information sharing." Another pause. "That's different from what you've asked before." It is. He knows it. She knows he knows it. She says she'll think about it. She does not say yes. That night Duke sits with the case file and the bourbon he hasn't touched in eight months and the knowledge that the case he's building might be the one that requires his daughter to choose between her methodology and his. He leaves the bourbon where it is. Takes the pill. Opens the file.

Chapter 5: CARVER'S MOVE Carver accelerates the committee timeline. He has heard — through sources Duke doesn't yet know he has — that Duke is investigating the footnote. The committee hearing is moved from sixty days to thirty. Duke has thirty days to build what he needed sixty days to build. He calls everyone. Park. Raoul. Ortiz. Tommy. Alana Chen, now at the DOJ. Victoria, who he hasn't spoken to in eighteen months. Victoria declines. She has one more piece of intelligence. She delivers it by letter — physical, delivered by hand. The letter contains one name Duke doesn't know. Carver's primary contact inside the federal committee. A name that will take Duke ten days to fully understand and five days to act on. Total: fifteen days. Leaving fifteen.

Chapter 6: THE CONTACT The federal committee contact is a career civil servant — thirty-one years in federal data governance policy. Not compromised in the way the Circuit usually compromises people. Something more complicated: she has been persuaded. Carver has spent three years making the case to her, genuinely, that the data integration standard he is proposing will help the populations it serves. She believes him. She is not stupid. She is not corrupt. She has been given a carefully curated picture of the evidence, built by someone who spent fifteen years learning exactly which evidence to curate. Duke has to make her see what Carver kept out of the picture in fifteen days. He is not sure he can do it with his methodology alone.

Chapter 7: RESIDUE SAYS YES Julie calls. She has thought about it. "Full information sharing. No subordination of timelines. If Residue identifies an intervention that conflicts with the legal case timeline, we talk before either of us moves." "Agreed." "And Duke—" A pause. "When this is over, I need you to understand something about what I've built. Not approve it. Not endorse it. Understand it." "I'll try." She doesn't say that's enough. She says: "I know." They work the case together for the first time since Book 1. It is not the same as it was in Book 1. They are not the same. But the pattern recognition is running in the same direction for the first time in three years. It is something.

Chapter 8: THE YOUNGSTOWN FAMILY Duke goes to Youngstown. Alone. No Raoul, no Tommy. He sits with the family for two days. Not interviewing — listening. Seven years of rolling administrative crisis, all traceable to a data flag placed in 2016 by the Baltimore pilot. One flag. Seven years. Three kids who grew up in the specific exhaustion of a family navigating systems designed to be unnavigable. Duke writes it down. Not shorthand — full sentences. He has not written in full sentences since he was a journalist. He is going to need to write in full sentences for what comes next. The case requires something different from what he has built before. Not a filing. Not a federal complaint. Something that can be read by the committee members in a format they cannot administratively process into irrelevance. He is going to have to be a journalist again. The thought arrives without drama. He files it. Drives west.

ACT II: THE RECORD (Chapters 9–18) Duke builds the case through two parallel instruments: his investigative methodology and his writing. The journalism is the weapon Carver never accounted for because Duke stopped using it fifteen years ago.

Chapter 9: THE DOCUMENT Duke begins writing what will become the foundational document of the federal case — not a legal filing, a piece of journalism. Long-form. Fully documented. The

complete history of the mechanism from the 2012 Hopkins grant through the 2019 footnote through the current committee timeline. He writes it the way he investigated: completely, sequentially, nothing skimmed. Tommy builds the digital architecture around it. Julie maps the data evidence. Park reviews every legal claim. Ortiz verifies every law enforcement element. It is the most collaborative thing Duke has ever built. It is still, undeniably, his.

Chapters 10–15: THE INVESTIGATION [Summary] The middle section of Book 3 is the investigation running on dual tracks — the journalism and the legal case — with the committee deadline as the clock. Key beats across these chapters:

- Tommy's sister: she reaches out. She wants out. The Circuit's cultural operation has been her world for four years. She is not sure she knows how to leave it. Tommy makes a decision that costs him professionally and costs Residue operationally and is the correct human choice. Duke, watching Tommy make it, understands something about his own accounting that he has been avoiding.
- Ortiz and the justice platform: she identifies the mechanism by which the justice-adjacent data flags are being placed. It is not through a court. It is through a county administrative interface that has federal database write access. She can shut it down. The shutdown requires going outside official channels. She goes outside official channels. Duke watches an honest cop do an unauthorized thing for a completely defensible reason and understands why Julie does what Julie does.
- Carver's response to the document: he knows it's being written. He cannot suppress it — it's not in a database he controls. He attempts to discredit Duke. Not through the mechanism — through journalism. He commissions a profile of Duke Savage that runs in a sympathetic publication, characterizing him as a paranoid, addiction-compromised investigator with a personal vendetta against federal data governance policy. The profile is accurate in its facts and dishonest in its framing. Duke reads it. He doesn't respond. He takes the Tuesday pill. He writes the next section.
- Alana Chen at the DOJ: she has been quietly building the federal case from the inside. Her position is more precarious now — Carver has identified her as the source Victoria used. She is not fired. She is isolated. Her institutional access is narrowing by the week. She gives Duke everything she has before it narrows further. The evidence is enough. Park says: it's enough. Duke says: it's enough for the legal case. It's not enough to stop the committee vote.

Chapter 16: THE COMMITTEE Ten days before the vote. Duke publishes the document. Not through a newspaper — through Tommy's open architecture, distributed simultaneously to every federal committee member, every major investigative journalism outlet, every federal data governance researcher in the country, and the specific community organizations in seven cities whose populations have been living inside the mechanism for eleven years. It is not a leak. It is not a submission. It is a public record, placed in the hands of everyone who should have had it.

Duke signs it with his name. The Circuit cannot delete it. It is in too many places. It is paper and it is digital and it is in the hands of the people it describes and in the hands of the people who can act on it. The phone starts ringing at 4:47 a.m. Duke lets it ring.

Chapter 17: THE FALLOUT The committee hearing is postponed indefinitely. The federal data governance standard is withdrawn from consideration. Carver's name is in the document. In print. Publicly. Permanently. His federal advisory working group position is suspended. His attorneys are managing a criminal exposure that is, for the first time, genuinely serious. CONTINUUM's county contracts are terminated. The justice-adjacent platform is shut down. The open architecture standard from Book 2's consent decree is adopted voluntarily by three states as a direct consequence of the document's publication. The mechanism is wounded. More deeply than before. It is not destroyed. It never will be. But Thomas R. Carver is in the record now. Not a footnote. The subject.

Chapter 18: DUKE AND JULIE They meet the morning after the document publishes. Her apartment. The lamp on. They sit with coffee and the specific quality of a morning when something large has been completed and what comes next is not yet visible. Julie says: "I want to show you something." She shows him Residue. Not the operation — the results. Documented over three years: 847 interventions. People whose records were restored before they lost housing. People whose medication access was reinstated before they lost stability. Forty-seven of the original Baltimore families, tracked through the correction process and into something that was not quite stability but was not crisis. Jerome, whose records were restored, who is working part-time, who is not hospitalised, who does not know Residue's name. Duke looks at the documentation for a long time. He says: "How many of them know what you did." "None of them." "Why." "Because they didn't ask for intervention. They asked for their records back. I gave them their records back. What I am to them is irrelevant. The outcome is what matters." Duke hears himself in that. The journalist who signed the document with his name. The investigator who needs the record to say what happened and who did it. Julie doesn't need the record to say her name. She needs the outcome. He looks at his daughter. He does not say he was wrong. He does not say she was right. He says: "It's good work, Julie." She receives it without performance. They drink the coffee.

ACT III: THE LAST AUDIT (Chapters 19–26)

Chapter 19: WHAT'S LEFT Carver is managing his criminal exposure. He will not be destroyed. He will be wounded, managed, diminished — and he will adapt. Duke knows this. He has always known this. The mechanism evolves. The record accumulates. The question Book 3 ends on is not whether the mechanism can be stopped. It is whether the record is enough. Duke doesn't know the answer. He has never known the answer. He has kept building the record anyway.

Chapter 20: RAOUL Raoul and Duke in the El Sereno park. Full circle. Not the same bench — a different location. Same sightlines. Raoul has spent three years running his community network alongside Residue without fully acknowledging that he's running it alongside Residue. He and Julie have been coordinating. Duke suspected. He didn't pull on it. Raoul tells him now. "She

built something that does what you do from the other direction. The two of you together cover more ground than either of you alone." "She doesn't want to do it together." "She's been doing it together for three years. She just doesn't want to be managed while she does it." Duke sits with that. The food wrappers gathered. The park doing its ordinary operations. "The families on your watch list," Duke says. "Eleven active. Three stable." "The three Baltimore families." "Two stable. One still in process." "Still in process after eleven years." "Yes." Silence. "It doesn't close," Raoul says. "No. It doesn't."

Chapter 21: TOMMY AND HIS SISTER Tommy's sister has left the Circuit's cultural operation. Not through extraction — through attrition. She simply stopped appearing at the events. Stopped answering the contacts. The Circuit let her go because letting her go cost less than the alternative, and because Tommy's operational profile had become, through three years of targeted disruption, expensive enough to make the calculation shift. She is not the person Tommy was looking for. She is someone who has been inside something for four years and has come out changed and is figuring out who she is now. Tommy is figuring out who he is without the search. The grief inventory. Moved at last. The building doesn't collapse. It stands differently.

Chapter 22: ORTIZ Ortiz has a conversation with her lieutenant — official, on the record, about the justice-adjacent platform and the administrative interface that allowed federal database writes without a court order. The conversation results in a formal departmental review. The review will take six months. The mechanism the review is examining will be shut down within the week because of Duke's document. She files the paperwork anyway. Because the record matters. Because the next version of the platform will be built, and when it is, the record of this one will be waiting. She and Duke speak briefly afterward. She says: "Same animal. Better cage." He says: "Different cages." She nods. She goes back to work.

Chapter 23: VICTORIA A letter. Physical. No return address. Postmarked London. Three paragraphs. Victoria Cross, who has been in England for eight months on the specific errand of becoming a person whose past is in another country. The letter doesn't describe her life. It describes one thing: a name she encountered in 1994, before any of this, in a room she was in before she understood what rooms like that were for. The name is Thomas R. Carver. He was in the mechanism before the mechanism had a name. She has been carrying this for three years. She is putting it down now. "I wanted you to have it before I stop looking back." Duke files it. He writes her name at the top of a page and her contribution underneath it and puts it in the case file that is no longer active but is not closed. He will not contact her. She does not want to be contacted. She is done. He respects this completely.

Chapter 24: CARVER'S LAST MOVE Carver does not go quietly. He is not the type. He is also not reckless. His last move is not against Duke. It is a repositioning — a new institutional home, a new advisory role, a different federal working group where his name doesn't yet carry the weight of the record. He is trying to find the clean room again. Duke tracks it. He documents it. He sends the documentation to Alana Chen at the DOJ, to Park, to the three investigative journalists who published chapters of the Book 3 document. He cannot stop Carver repositioning. He can make sure the repositioning is visible. Carver, in his new institutional

home, will find the record already arrived before him. This is what Duke does. He builds the record that gets there first.

Chapter 25: THE MOJAVE Before dawn. Duke drives east. The same service road. The same desert light. He does the cylinder check. The rounds are seated. He stands in the Mojave and does the accounting. Three books. Three cases. Three federal records. The mechanism is older than all of them. What changed is what's in the record. He hears a car on the service road. He doesn't turn around immediately. He already knows. Julie gets out of the car. She stands beside him. She doesn't explain why she's here. He doesn't ask. They stand in the desert in the specific quality of high desert light before the heat arrives, the two of them looking at the same horizon, running the same pattern recognition on the same landscape, arriving at the same conclusion from different methodologies. The audit was never closed. That's not a failure. That's the work. "What's next?" she says. He looks at her. She's asking the question Duke has been asking his whole career — but she's asking it toward something, not from something. She is not exhausted by it. She is oriented. He is both. "Carver is repositioning," he says. "I know. I've been watching it." "From Residue's side." "From Residue's side." A pause. Desert silence. "We could coordinate," she says. Not subordinate. Not merge. Coordinate. The distinction is everything. "On your terms," Duke says. "On honest terms." He looks at the horizon. The sun clearing the ridge. The Mojave in full light. "Okay," he says. One word. It carries everything. They stand there for another minute. Then they get in their cars and drive west. The same city. Two different directions. Both heading home.

Chapter 26: THE NEXT FILE The Arts District at 9:15 a.m. The desk. The coffee. Duke opens his laptop. The case file for the Youngstown family is closed. The Carver file is active federal record. The CONTINUUM file is closed. The justice platform file is closed. He opens a new file. It does not yet have a name. He sits with it for a moment. The city outside doing what cities do. Eleven million people in the basin going about their lives. The improbability of the whole enterprise normalized by its continuity. He starts typing. The audit was never closed. He wouldn't have it any other way.

EPILOGUE — BOOK 3 Six weeks later. Duke and Julie have dinner at a place on Flower Street. They do not talk about Carver. They do not talk about the cases. They talk about a restaurant she went to in Baltimore, on a Residue trip she doesn't describe in detail. They talk about the lamp she still keeps on. They talk about a letter he's been meaning to write for three years and hasn't. "Write it," she says. "I know." "Duke." "I know." She orders dessert. He drinks the coffee. When he leaves she walks him to the door. She doesn't hug him — she puts her hand briefly on his arm, the specific gesture of someone who is not yet ready for the fuller version but is no longer holding the door closed. He notes it. He doesn't say anything about it. He walks to the car. Looks back once. Her window. The lamp on the right side. Specific. Located. Not moving. He drives east.

THE END

SERIES THEMATIC ARCHITECTURE

BOOK 1: Truth wounds the mechanism. Duke wins. Partially. The record exists. The audit is never closed. The thing Duke was most afraid of (Julie in danger because of him) is replaced by something he didn't know to be afraid of: Julie beyond his reach because she chose to be.

BOOK 2: Truth maps the architecture above the mechanism. Duke and Julie operate in parallel for the first time. The professional tension cracks something open. She becomes fully herself in a way that doesn't include Duke as a fixed point. He has to live with that. The record grows. Carver is in it. The audit was never closed.

BOOK 3: Truth forces a choice between exposure and redesign. Duke and Julie coordinate — not merge, coordinate. On honest terms. Two methodologies. One direction. The mechanism adapts. The record accumulates. The last scene: the Mojave, together, looking at the same horizon. "What's next?" The audit was never closed. That's not a failure. That's the work.

SERIES CLOSING NOTE

The trilogy ends not with Duke destroying the mechanism but with Duke and Julie agreeing to coordinate against it. On honest terms. With full information sharing. Without subordination of either methodology.

That is the ending that earns everything that came before it. Not victory. Not defeat. A durable working arrangement between two people who love each other and have spent three books becoming capable of this specific agreement.

The lamp is still on. It always will be.